insisted otherwise. The general attitude of the authorities was one of toleration and restraint. Under the circumstances, it was as expected that the agitation grew from bad to worse. Riots and arson were the 'order' of the day and, by and large, the agitating students had a free hand in what they were doing.

She received an invitation from the Indian Institute of Public Administration, Delhi, to attend a seminar there for a week. Sending her there for that duration would have been sound strategy and could have diluted the agitation somewhat, but the authorities thought otherwise. The IG (P), Kulbir Singh, who was a non-Mizo, suggested to the chief secretary that he should allow her to go, but the CS was in no mood to accommodate her.

Without any will or determination on the state government's part to check the agitation, the situation had gone totally out of control. It was at this stage that Kiran was called to meet the law and education minister, Dr H. Thansanga, in his office at 7.30 one evening. She took along a Mizo officer whom she could trust and drove to the minister's office on that dark, rainy and chilly evening. The health minister was also present there. They explained to her how grave the students' unrest had become and asked her for her suggestions to tackle the problem. She told them that matters had to be taken in hand and a will to control the agitation must be shown. Unfortunately, she observed that there was nothing of the sort visible. On the contrary, the magistrates were shying away from their jobs and were not present at the scenes of law violation. They allowed small groups of 50 to 200 to swell into mobs of 1500 to 2000 and, consequently, declared that the law and order situation was completely out of control. A couple of such crisp volleys by Kiran and the ministers changed course. They suggested to her that the only way out of the situation was that she should surrender, in writing, her daughter's seat allocation. The administration, they contended, could do nothing about the situation and if she did not heed their advice then the matter would rest in the hands of the students who could even kill her. 'Kill me?' asked Kiran incredulously. 'Yes. Kill you', responded Dr Thansanga. She requested time to discuss the matter with her daughter and her family and was granted time till 8 a.m. the next day. On that note, the meeting ended.

Promptly at 8 a.m. Dr Thansanga called her residence. She told him that she was still trying to get across to her family in Delhi over the telephone. She was then told that, in defiance of the prohibitory orders, the students would be collecting at 10 a.m. and that if the information on the withdrawal of seat allocation was not given to them, then they would take matters into their own hands. She decided to take shelter by driving to the Raj Bhavan, the house of the governor, Swaraj Kaushal. Frantic calls were made to her office and residence to trace her whereabouts from the chief minister's office downwards. It was only when she informed the IG (P) that she was at the Raj Bhavan that the calls stopped. With the approval of the governor, Kiran Bedi drove out of Mizoram for good at midnight.

Back in Delhi, Kiran spoke to the press:

> Controversies, troubles, brickbats, fierce opposition … all these are not new to me. When I devoted my life to the Indian Police Service (IPS), I embraced all these and more, as part and parcel of my fate. Remember the Akali agitation when thousands of Akalis brandishing naked swords had charged towards the police in a frenzy, and I clashed with them with only a *danda* (baton) in my hand? Well, I forget the exact date when the incident occurred, but in retrospect, I am sure that it was not physical force but a psychological pressure from my side which made the crowd flee. My attitude to the incident, as my attitude towards anything, was simple. There was my target, and here was I. That I had to succeed was the only thought at the back of my mind, and whatever I did thereafter, was a reflex action. My motto in life is that nothing is impossible, no target unachievable – one just has to try harder and harder.